HOPEFULS



NIKHAT ZAREEN, 26
BOXING

Nikhat Zareen's life has enough fodder to merit a biopic. It begins with her as a 13-year-old tomboy visiting the Collector Ground in Nizamabad to see girls play all sports except boxing. It moves to her picking up the gloves with her father's support and against the backlash from conservative members of society. There are many highs—becoming a youth world champion and then winning the senior world title not once but twice—and lows, including a shoulder injury and losing to Mary Kom for a seat to the Tokyo Olympic qualifier. But the happy ending to Zareen's inspiring story is yet to come. There's one title that eludes her and she covets most—Olympic champion.

In that context, the Games take on renewed significance, for Hangzhou is a crucial layover in Zareen's bid to win in Paris 2024. If Zareen wins the Asian Games gold, she qualifies for her first Olympics. She has left no stone unturned in her preparation, which entailed sparring with boxers from Russia and the Philippines, training in China for a three-week-long national camp and following the plan Boxing Federation of India's director of high performance, Bernard Dunne, has devised for her.

For the initial part of her career, Zareen lived under the shadow of Mary Kom, who reigned supreme in the flyweight category globally for nearly a decade. But post-Tokyo, with Kom retiring, Zareen seized the spotlight. She now carries the expectations that come with being a frontrunner in her category. "First, I had to do well for myself, for I knew my capabilities," she says. "When a player reaches a certain level, responsibility begins to convert into pressure and many aren't able to perform. Sometimes, I thrive playing under pressure. It pushes you to not settle for less."

> **"I am giving it my all because I know how important it is for me to win gold. It's a do-or-die situation"**

She has had this spirited approach since childhood. Her playmates then were boys. "That fearless, *'karna hai'* attitude, I got from them," she says. In her childhood, Zareen never saw her gender as a deterrent. Initially a sprinter, she called it a *'chul'*—a kick—to "prove to people that girls are strong and they can take up boxing". As the accolades have come in the ring, Zareen is pleased with the effects of her results outside of it. "After winning the World Championship, I got calls asking when I would be back in Hyderabad because young girls aspiring to be boxers wanted to meet me," she says.

It is great for Indian sport that Zareen's *chul* is still alive and kicking in adulthood. It's why she could move from the flyweight to the light flyweight category in a year and emerge as a world champion in that too. "Losing two kilos seems small, but maintaining speed, strength and power is challenging," she says. The change has required her to exercise more self-control towards her diet, but "the sacrifice" of carbs and sugar is all worth it to "represent the country and do it proud".

-Suhani Singh

INDIA AT THE ASIAD

THE INDIAN CONTINGENT FINISHED 8TH WITH ITS HIGHEST-EVER MEDAL HAUL AT THE 2018 ASIAN GAMES IN JAKARTA AND PALEMBANG

70
TOTAL MEDALS WON

16
23
31

PAST SHOWINGS

YEAR	FINISH	TOTAL	GOLD
2014	8th	57	11
2010	6th	65	14
2006	8th	53	10
2002	7th	36	11